

A NEW LOOK Ali Sethi and Shae Gill; and (right) Zulfiqar Jabbar Khan

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Still reeling from the effects of Omicron, the world felt gloomy when Coke Studio Pakistan released the first song of its 14th season on January 14. Performed by Abida Parveen and folk artiste Naseebo Lal, 'Tu Jhoom' proved to be distraction, yes, but it was also prescription. The song wanted us to rejoice in the face of adversity, to delight despite our despair. For ardent followers, though, the song was also a departure. Gone was the familiar, cosy studio. In its place, we had a plush music video.

Speaking to INDIA TODAY over a Zoom call from Lahore, Coke Studio producer Zulfiqar Jabbar Khan (or Xulfi, as he is known) says, "Try and recall the first few frames of 'Tu Jhoom'. The setting is dark. What you see looks almost like the old Coke Studio, but in the next 30 seconds, it transfers you to the new Coke Studio. The light comes in to reveal the artistry, the imagery, dancers, the theatrics."

In its 13 earlier avatars, Coke Studio thrived on a kind of musical chemistry which often results only from collective immersion. When trusted with Season 14, Xulfi wanted to take his inheritance a few steps further: "I wanted to capture all of your senses—your intellect, your feelings. It had to be an irresistible spectacle." Dropped over nine weeks, each of Coke Studio's 13 songs came to us in a shiny package that gave us the option of *seeing* the music we were listening to. "There needs to be a visual movement to the story you are telling sonically. That's what makes a connect," says Xulfi.

Narratives are important to Xulfi. He feels everyone—whether an art director, choreographer, make-up artist or cinematographer—is a storyteller. Part of the Coke Studio band in previous seasons, Action Zain (Zain Ali) was brought on as an associate music producer this year. He says that while experimentation and collaboration have always been at the heart of Coke Studio's success, Season 14 also felt extremely inclusive: "Ideas were allowed to flow freely; nothing was off limits. I was constantly being encouraged to stay authentic, to be myself."

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When Zain was given a demo recording of the qawwali 'Thagyan', his first response was to strip it of all its qawwali elements. "What I had left was an interesting groove and baseline, an interesting way to move the melody." Though 'Thagyan', in the end, retains the customary qawwali crescendo, the love it speaks of is more romantic than it is spiritual. Sung by the celebrated Quratulain Baloch and Zain Zohaib, a young Pakistani qawwali group, it teases old boundaries, instead of fully breaking them.

Season 14 did, of course, leave some Coke Studio traditions intact. With every song, we were given a behind-the-scenes 'Magical Journey' video that made our listening and watching more intimate. We see Baloch and other Coke Studio veterans like Meesha Shafi almost wonderstruck by the platform's makeover. At times, these videos perform a separate function—they help musicians spell out for us the true intent of their songs.

Ali Sethi, for instance, passionately tells his fellow singer, Shae Gill, that the theme of their Punjabi song 'Pasoori' is more profound than the tribulations of a difficult love: "We live in this very polarised world where borders and boundaries of all sorts have become more rigid. 'Pasoori' [dilemma] is about someone who is oppressing you, who is preventing people who want to be together from meeting." 'Pasoori' has since gone viral with 70 million views on YouTube and 20 million hits on Spotify. Gill, 23, says, "When the song was in its creation process, I knew